A trumpet-inspired chess set

PHOTOGRAPHS BY MIKE DARLOW, UNLESS OTHERWISE STATED

In the latest part of his series on chess sets, **Mike Darlow** turns a set based on a trumpet-shape design

My finished pieces turned in Australian blackwood (*Acacia melanoxylon*) and European ash (*Fraxinus excelsior*)

MIKE DARLOW

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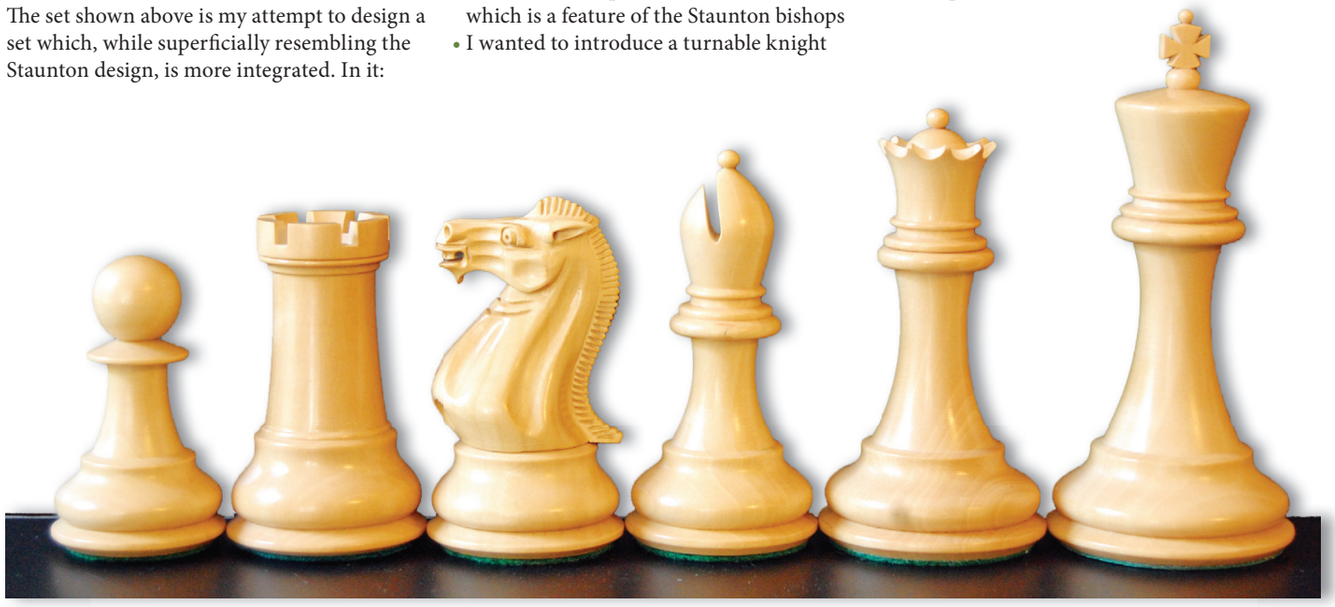
The set shown above is my attempt to design a set which, while superficially resembling the Staunton design, is more integrated. In it:

- I've adopted a trumpet-shaped piece signature with a splayed top for all pieces
- My king is the tallest piece
- The crowns of the king and queen conform with the Staunton precedent. Thus my king's crown is arched and the queen's pointed
- The king has four adjacent rings beneath the arched crown, the queen has three rings, the bishop two, and the knight one
- I decided to keep the narrow canted slot, which is a feature of the Staunton bishops
- I wanted to introduce a turnable knight piece signature. I chose an early 19th-century dragoon's helmet and carved away part of the turned ring to represent the helmet's peak
- I wanted to use a square-in-plan battlement design, an unusual but not rare feature – several are shown in George Dean's sumptuous 2010 book *Chess Masterpieces*
- Rather than the usual sphere, I decided to use a hemispherical helmet-shaped top on the pawns



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Chess pieces of the Staunton design produced by the House of Staunton

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